CHAPTER 6

Creating a Culture of Levity

"I'm struck by how laughter connects you with people. It's almost impossible to maintain any kind of distance or any sense of social hierarchy when you're just howling with laughter."

—John Cleese

Toy Story was one of the most creatively ambitious, lucrative, and trailblazing films of a generation. The world's first feature length computer-animated film, it was a quaint tale about the adventures of a ragtag band of lovable toys who come alive when humans are out of sight.

In many ways, the making of the movie mirrored the plot itself. The small, impassioned creative team would routinely pull all-nighters during which the eclectic bunch of engineers and animators at Pixar would—not unlike Woody and Buzz—come alive.

Pixar's culture was imbued with an infectious, energizing spirit of levity and play. Some nights, that meant mini-golf tournaments and scooter races in the cramped hallways of their Los Angeles studio. (These recurring contests were so competitive that senior producer Tom Porter was once awoken at home in the middle of the night to return to the studio and protect his long-held record.) The interns held elaborate dress-down Fridays, showing up in matching costumes like Jedis or Cub Scouts. The company hosted "Pixarpalooza," with as many as twenty different bands of Pixar employees playing covers of their favorite songs.

But these traditions didn't come at the cost of productivity. In fact, many regard Pixar's teams as some of the most hardworking and productive in the industry.

This was no happy accident. Ed Catmull, the former president of Pixar and Walt Disney Animation Studios, believed that levity and play were foundational to building productive, creative teams. This is a theory validated by research: In a study of 352 employees across 54 teams, researchers Nale Lehmann-Willenbrock and Joseph Allen videotaped hourlong team meetings and then analyzed supervisors' ratings of team performance. The teams that had humor demonstrated more functional communication and problem-solving behaviors, and performed better as a team, both during the meeting itself and over time. It was exactly this kind of playful culture that allowed the teams at Pixar to thrive.

Under Catmull's leadership, Pixar launched blockbusters like *A Bug's Life*, *Monsters, Inc.*, and *Finding Nemo* and developed the cutting-edge computer technology that revolutionized animated film (and made grown adults weep over bugs, fish, and fuzzy blue monsters in the process). In Catmull's view, that success was due in large part to the camaraderie and resilience among workers at Pixar, which was itself a product of the laughter-filled culture they'd cultivated. As Catmull reflected, "Lots of humor and levity in the good times solidify the relationships, making it easier for people to call on one another during the hard times."

In short, it came down to culture.

It seems obvious that a culture in which employees can do their best work while having fun is desirable. So why do so many workplaces feel like they're straight out of *Office Space*?*1

If yours is one of them, this chapter is for you. In the pages that follow, we'll offer stories, frameworks, and tips that will help you cultivate a culture of humor and levity at your organization.

But before diving in, we want to stress that the application of these techniques isn't universal. You might be comfortable in the spotlight, pulling your company's culture toward you, or instead prefer to influence culture more indirectly by elevating a charismatic co-worker or altering your office's physical space. Like eating a Reese's, there's no one way to build culture.

Your mission, should you choose to accept it, is to refract each principle and tactic through your authentic leadership style and your unique organization—then adopt the ones that are most resonant. In the process, you'll foster stronger relationships and empower your teams to do their best work, all while creating the kind of environment where people *want* to work.

Set the Tone from the Top

Unsurprisingly, leaders have a disproportionate influence on organizational culture. One of the most effective ways we've seen leaders engender a culture of levity is by publicly embodying—and enabling—humor, sending strong, consistent signals that levity and play are desired and embraced.

SHOWCASE YOUR FUNNY

We've explored many stories of leaders showcasing their humor: how Leslie Blodgett's ad in *The New York Times* got employees buzzing; how Stephen Curry's spirited impression of Steve Ballmer relaxed his team of partners and allowed them to feel more comfortable; how Richard Branson's daring helicopter stunt matched his cheeky prank when he landed, reinforcing that play was valued and encouraged at Virgin. What these stories—and the ones you are about to read—have in common is that they allow leaders to signal that they aren't the type to take themselves too seriously. These public displays of levity set the tone for the culture and give tacit permission for others in the organization to follow their lead.

Spontaneous humor is a common tool used by those CEOs who are most effective at setting a tone of levity. Why is it so effective? Surprise! (No, there's no actual surprise. The answer is "surprise.") When humor feels planned, you lose the crucial element of surprise. In this way, a punch line should come like a punch. If your audience is braced for impact, it's harder to knock them out. (And they're uncomfortable waiting for you to deliver it.) No wonder one of the first pieces of advice most comedians give to noncomedians is never to start a story with "I have a funny story…." When people perceive that you're trying to be funny, all of a sudden you have something to prove.

Organic humor has a far lower bar. When you are simply reacting to the moment (the "here and now" from trusty chapter 3), anything even *slightly* surprising or unserious—the smallest gesture of play—can elicit laughter. In short: If it feels planned, it better be good. If you're onstage and accidentally drop a peanut, it's comedic gold.

It's easy for us to say "Go be spontaneously funny!" but doing so in practice is far more difficult. That's why we suggest focusing on creating favorable conditions for spontaneous humor that doesn't feel forced. And the simplest way to do that is to showcase where it already exists—your most naturally playful, fun work relationships.

Dick Costolo was no stranger to this strategy; while at Twitter, he had a number of employees he'd call on to fill this role. Among them was April Underwood, a longtime colleague and senior product director whom Costolo would periodically invite onstage for companywide presentations.

The two knew each other well from working together at Google, and their playful, preexisting rapport helped Costolo come across as a real person—with a real sense of humor. By inviting Underwood onstage, Costolo was tacitly establishing her as every other employee's proxy; seeing her play and rib the boss allowed them to vicariously do the same. As Underwood reflected, "There's no substitute for that moment when something unexpected happens and the people onstage respond to it with humor. The fact that it's unplanned, unfolding in the moment, makes it even funnier. And it was a safe way to do it, because we could play off each other in a way that was completely natural—and fun."

A similar dynamic is at play in those *SNL* sketches in which actors "break" character and laugh at their own hilarity. It works because we can see the actors as humans in a moment that they're experiencing along with us—which can sometimes be even funnier than the sketch they planned. The actor is no longer ahead of the audience. By giving up control to Underwood and reacting in real time, Costolo lets everyone else be in the moment with him.

This is a technique that Google's founders, Larry Page and Sergey Brin—along with Eric Schmidt, when he later joined as CEO—used from the start.

Not long after Google's founding, Page and Brin instituted an hourlong companywide meeting at the end of each week called TGIF (Thank Goodness It's Friday).[*2] For the first thirty minutes, the team reviewed news and product launches from the past week, provided demos for unreleased products, and celebrated recent wins. The final thirty minutes consisted of a question-and-answer session during which any Google employee could query[*3] the leadership team about anything they wanted.

Googlers enjoyed both the subject matter and the style in which the meetings were held. They loved the fact that no topic was off the table, from cellphone features to election results. But the witty repartee between Page and Brin (and later Schmidt as well) was often the real highlight, especially when Brin's farcical sense of humor was on full display.

TGIF at Google frequently resembled a comedy show. Schmidt recalled that "the humor came out completely naturally" when the two of them were onstage together; they were able to play off

each other, showcasing the lighthearted banter they enjoyed behind closed doors.

The leaders' goal was clear and purposeful: to inspire a relaxed form of leadership. As Schmidt reflected, "You get the leadership you inspire. If the leadership of the company is relaxed and humorous and having fun, the other people will have permission, within the appropriate boundaries, to do the same thing."

They set a cultural tone that has remained consistent for over twenty years: Google is a company where people were empowered to have fun and be themselves.

Of course, not all leaders are comfortable putting their own sense of humor on display.[*4] But there are plenty of ways to cultivate a culture of levity and signal that humor is valued in your organization without putting yourself in the spotlight.

PLAY ALONG

One of the first rules of improv comedy is the concept of "Yes, and"—the rule that when your scene partner makes an offer (either explicitly or implied), you always agree with the premise and add something new to it. In *Bossypants*, Tina Fey explains:

> If I start a scene with "I can't believe it's so hot in here," and you just say, "Yeah…," we're kind of at a standstill.
>
> But if I say, "I can't believe it's so hot in here," and you say, "What did you expect? We're in hell." Or if I say, "I can't believe it's so hot in here," and you say, "Yes, this can't be good for the wax figures." Or if I say, "I can't believe it's so hot in here," and you say, "I told you we shouldn't have crawled into this dog's mouth," now we're getting somewhere.

The "Yes, and" approach adds to the scene, helps the humor develop, and establishes trust between scene partners.

The surest path to encouraging a culture of levity is to "Yes, and" the levity that arises naturally from co-workers and teams, argues Kelly Leonard, author of—wait for it—*Yes, And.*

Nowhere is this more important (or acutely felt) than when grassroots acts of levity come at your own expense. As the CEO of Rover, a popular platform that matches pet owners with

experienced dog walkers and pet sitters in their area, Aaron Easterly says he routinely encourages his employees to make their own fun, even if it involves making fun of him.

Case in point: On the morning of the company's eighth anniversary, Easterly's team decided to honor the occasion with doughnuts and a homespun party game entitled Two Truths and a Lie: The How Well Do You Know Aaron Easterly Contest. The quiz was just ten questions, each consisting of three facts about Easterly. As you've likely inferred (you are a smart bunch), two were true and one was a lie; the challenge was to guess the lie.

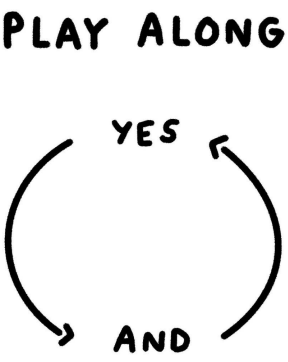
Some (embarrassing) truths the game revealed about Easterly:

- He once purchased a stick shift Jeep, forgetting momentarily that he didn't know how to drive a stick shift.
- He showed up to a board of directors dinner and was unable to eat it because he'd filled up on Fudge Stripes on the walk over.
- He once mistakenly referred to a roomful of MSN executives as being from AOL multiple times during a pitch.

"And so all the dumb things that I've done for a twenty-year span were immortalized," Easterly recalls. Instead of worrying about his most embarrassing screw-ups being meticulously documented for his colleagues' amusement, he joined in on the fun, played along, and elaborated on the stories at his employees' eager requests.

Former Google chairman Eric Schmidt also knows a thing or two about not getting in the way of humor at his expense. Back when he was the head of product development at Sun Microsystems, Schmidt arrived at work one day to find a Volkswagen Beetle in the middle of his office. It seemed that several next-level pranksters had purchased the vehicle, taken it apart, carted it into his office overnight, and reassembled it before he arrived in the morning.[*5] Schmidt knew that his reaction to this elaborate trick (and act of mechanical wizardry) was quite important. He recalled, "I said to myself, 'Oh well. My schedule has changed and now it's time to play along.' "

Instead of pulling away, he leaned (or more accurately, *walked*) into his team's humor, conducting meetings inside the Beetle for the next few days.



Embrace the Underground

At Pixar, Ed Catmull saw the zany rituals that filled the halls with laughter, delight, and cute furry monsters as the true connective tissue of the company. But he's never believed that it's a leader's job to try to dictate the terms of culture from on high. As he says: "Fun is not a top-down thing."

On the contrary, a culture of levity can—and must—come from all levels. And if you look, you'll find potential energy all around. In our interviews, we found that the sources of this potential—the employees who can help create this culture—were commonly described as one of three archetypes: **Instigators, Culture Carriers,** and **Hidden Gems**.

Culture Carriers are natural leaders and rising stars in the organization, for whom humor also happens to be a natural strength. **Hidden Gems** are diligent, under-the-radar high performers, who provide unexpected opportunities for levity. And **Instigators** are rabble-rousers[*6] and rule breakers who do things differently and tend to be nonconformist by nature.

How to leverage each archetype—and the degree of their impact on your organization—depends on your current culture and goals. Throw an Instigator into Pixar, and she may fit right in. Throw an Instigator into the Yankees clubhouse, though, and he may shake things up. Or, rather, he *did* shake things up.

Instigators

There are few workplaces with higher stakes or higher pressure than Major League Baseball. And yet, as New York Yankees legend Alex Rodriguez tells it, a culture of levity was a key driver of the Yankees' 2009 World Series title. But just a few years earlier, the culture couldn't have been more different.

Even if you don't know a bunt from a balk,[*7] you have heard of the New York Yankees—the most storied team in baseball. But with so much history and tradition comes a certain aversion to rocking the boat. Longtime Yankees owner George Steinbrenner, who ran the team for thirty-seven years, even famously instituted a strict policy on hair: nothing long in the back, and no facial hair other than mustaches. "We were the Goldman Sachs of baseball," Rodriguez joked.

But when the team gathered for spring training in 2006, there was a lot of buzz—and not all of it good—around one of the team's new additions: center fielder Johnny Damon, who had been acquired from the rival Red Sox in the offseason.

Damon was colorful, to say the least. He reveled in attention. He drove a black Ferrari. He titled his autobiography *Idiot*. He once dropped a pumpkin off his thirty-fourth-floor balcony for kicks. How would a guy like this—a textbook Instigator—fit into the formal culture of the Yankees clubhouse?

He didn't. And that's why it worked. On day one, says Rodriguez, Damon walked into the clubhouse "at six in the morning, with his boom box playing Kid Rock really, really loud" (to be fair,

it would feel deeply inappropriate to play Kid Rock quietly). “It was a *moment,*” Rodriguez recalled.

Rather than making unwanted waves, the lighthearted energy Damon brought to the team electrified the group. “It unlocked a lot of people’s sense of humor,” Rodriguez said. Not only that, “it made us play better. It made us relax and our performance improved.” It wasn’t long before other players were getting in on the fun. Pitcher AJ Burnett started a new tradition: Every time a teammate hit a home run or had a walk-off hit to end a game, Burnett would be waiting to smash them in the face with a pie.

Damon’s energy was infectious, and Rodriguez recognized early how it helped the Yankees thrive: “In a world of sabermetrics where everyone is being appraised by numbers—home runs, RBI, slugging percentages—there are people who walk into the clubhouse and are game changers. People who shift the ambiance, the energy. It makes the clubhouse lighter and as a result, the team plays better.”

Damon, and Instigators like him, challenge the culture head-on. While their approaches tend to be riskier and more disruptive, they can also prompt cultural step changes—but only if leaders, like Rodriguez, are perceptive and flexible enough to embrace them and recognize their impact.

When Pixar’s culture hit a bump in the road, it was the Instigators who spearheaded the turnaround. As Catmull reflected, years after the company’s founding, the early employees (once known for being a young and rowdy group) had moved into a different phase of life. Many had started families and were raising young children, so instead of staying late after work to have fun together and decompress (read: launch rockets made from five-gallon water cooler jugs[*8] in the parking lot, once shattering a car windshield), they’d leave early to be with their families. As a new crop of youngsters joined the company, they took their social cues from the more staid culture that had taken root. As Catmull describes, he woke up one day and realized: “We’ve lost our fun.”

Catmull’s response was to call on his Instigators, surface his observations, and encourage them to take larger cultural swings. According to Catmull, all it took was this nudge of encouragement and the Instigators kicked into gear, rallying the troops, breaking rules, and reigniting the fun. After one such nudging, the Animation Department decided to dismantle an old truck. Then over the weekend, without asking for permission, they reassembled the truck in the middle of the Animation Area. While a truck in the studio might seem inconvenient to some, as Catmull puts it simply, “These are great signals.”

When the culture strays off course, Instigators are catalysts—lightning bolts of fun who reignite the subversion and playfulness. Says Catmull: “There will always be people in the company who are a little ‘out there.’ If everyone were like them, people probably wouldn’t get much done. But the culture needs some of these people, because they signal to everyone else that it’s okay to be different.”

Identifying and elevating these Instigators encourages fun and play and signals that it’s okay to break rules, break windshields, and blast Kid Rock every once in a while.

Culture Carriers

Culture Carriers are your rising stars who are widely respected throughout the organization and also happen to have an affinity for humor and play. If supported and elevated, they can be a secret weapon in cultivating an enduring, contagious culture of levity.

To illustrate their role, let's travel back to 2015 and drop by the fast-growing online education startup Coursera. CEO (and former president of Yale University) Rick Levin was beginning his weekly all-hands meeting as usual, running through a list of current priorities and progress achieved. But this particular meeting featured an uninvited guest. The mystery man peered eerily through his Google Glass headset from behind Levin as he began heckling the distinguished CEO while employees looked on, mesmerized and delighted.

The man *appeared* to be Sebastian Thrun, CEO of Coursera's top competitor, Udacity. As the meeting went on, his taunts became more and more aggressive. With the demeanor of an unhinged supervillain, he routinely interrupted Levin's remarks to lambaste his rival CEO, as well as Coursera itself in an absurdly dramatized German accent: "Oooo…you think you ist so fancy und smart, yah? My self-driving cars vud drive circles around you!" he cackled.

These comedic diatribes were met with uproarious laughter and applause as Coursera's employees relished the over-the-top haranguing. Yet Levin remained unfazed.

"Thrun" was in fact Connor Diemand-Yauman, one of Coursera's earliest hires and by all accounts a star employee. Widely respected for his strong work ethic and rapid rise in the company, Diemand-Yauman was also infamous among colleagues for his mischievous sense of humor and his ability to breathe life into dry, mundane moments.

Months earlier, Diemand-Yauman had arrived at the company Halloween party in the very same Sebastian Thrun costume. Levin could simply have laughed along with the rest of his team at Diemand-Yauman's antics—but instead, he leaned in, using his position to showcase and amplify Diemand-Yauman's gesture by asking if he'd like to take "Thrun" more public.

By not only taking the shenanigans in stride but actively championing them, Levin consistently endorsed Diemand-Yauman and his approach to levity, giving room for others to do the same: "Rick and the other senior leaders stressed our agency in sculpting Coursera into the organization we aspired to work in," said Diemand-Yauman. "They gave us so much room to play, create joy, and find new ways to enhance the culture (and ultimately, our company's performance)."

Levin's recognition of Coursera's culture carriers was brilliant, reverberating, and profound. The result of their dynamic was a lasting culture of quirk and play at Coursera, which, years after Diemand-Yauman's departure, is still cited by employees as a primary driver for their coming to (and staying in) the organization.

To activate Culture Carriers, welcome them into the fray, sharing challenges and opportunities that they can help address from the bottom up. Treat them like peers, share organizational concerns, and allow them to solve key problems with you—adding their own flavor of play. You'll be cultivating the growth of someone who can provide major value, both now and in the future.

Hidden Gems

Our third archetype can be easy to miss. Hidden Gems are the high-performing, hardworking individuals who often fly under the radar with inspiring (and inspired) skills, quirks, and hobbies.

Let's revisit Hiroki Asai—the former head of Apple's Creative Design Studio who loved putting his creativity to work on companywide All Hands meetings. Prior to one particular All Hands meeting, Asai had learned that one of the more junior team members, a skilled and dedicated designer, was also a classically trained singer—a fact that few of her colleagues knew.

As Asai took the stage that day, he invited the employee to join him, explaining to the crowd that she was there to share a recent win from her team. But as soon as she took the mic, the curtains of the enormous stage swung open to reveal a hidden gospel choir, who immediately broke into song, backing up the exceptionally talented employee who had begun belting onstage.

The room erupted in delight as more performers, who had been secretly planted among the audience, danced their way toward the stage. The auditorium was filled with cheers of appreciation, laughter, and harmony (both musical and interpersonal) as the singer brought the house down in front of her two thousand colleagues.

While you might not think a flash mob gospel choir screams (or sings) "good for business," Asai would disagree.

First, spotlighting the unique talents of Hidden Gems—these diligent, often overlooked high performers who live in all corners of your organization—is a potent recipe for humor, and the joy that comes with it. It comes back to an ingredient we know and love: the inherent *surprise* of revealing their talents creates a moment of delight. It doesn't need to be funny, it just needs to be true to prompt laughter and joy.

Far beyond this moment of shared laughter, it helps to shape the culture in a more profound and lasting way. As Asai saw it, by elevating the Hidden Gems in his organization (the "quiet heroes," as he called them), he was signaling that every person in the organization—regardless of tenure or status—was valued not just for what they produced at work, but for what they loved to do outside work. It signaled that whatever your unique passions and personality are, they are welcome here. Hidden Gems are some of your most powerful allies in sending this message.

And the relationship goes the other way as well: When people feel comfortable bringing their whole selves to work—personal passions, quirks, things that make them unique and special—their senses of humor will come as well.

Institutionalize Levity

So you've said some witty things publicly (or at least signaled your sense of humor has a heartbeat) and found some killer Instigators / Culture Carriers / Hidden Gems who you're hellbent on unlocking. But you're not satisfied with that—you want to create a culture of levity that stands the test of time!

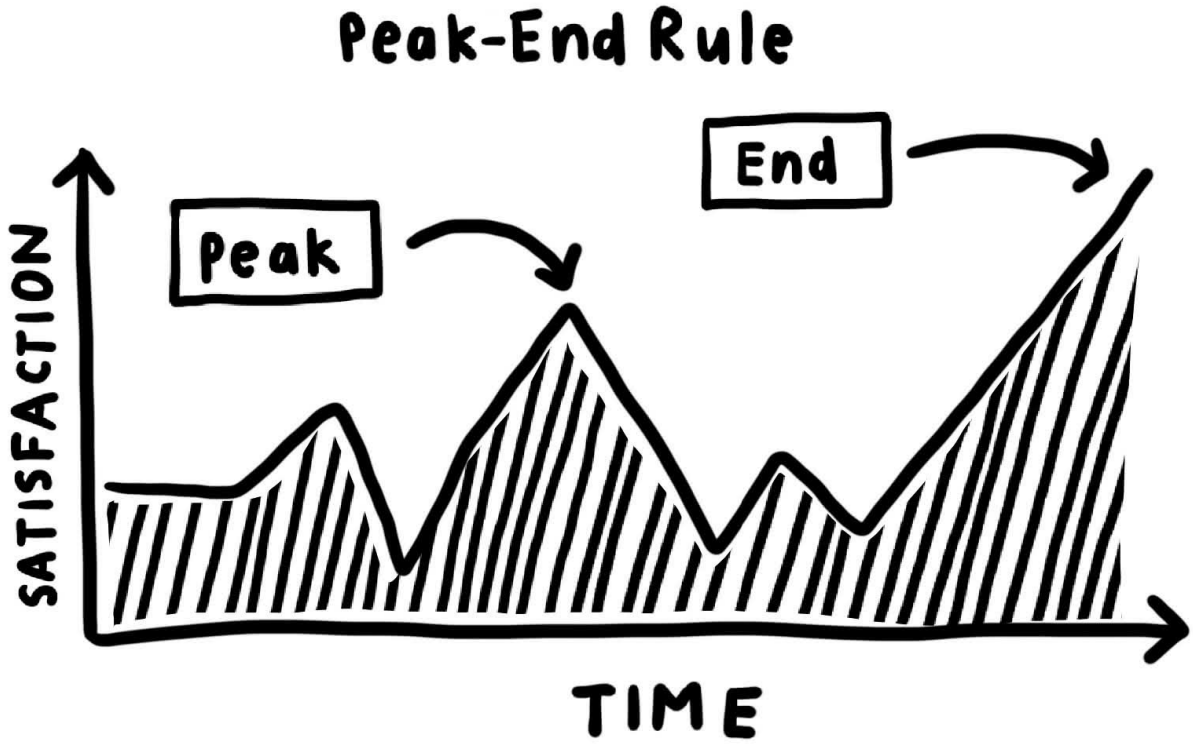
This brings us to the art of *institutionalizing* levity, building it into the fabric of your organization itself.

CURATE DEFINING MOMENTS

Pause for a moment and consider: What have been the most defining moments of your current job? When you think about what has been most memorable and important—that had the most impact on how you feel about your job—which moments come to mind?

Our brains are wired in such a way that we remember our lives less like a film strip of the experience unfolding than like a series of snapshots. And these snapshots—those that flooded your mind when you paused to reflect—are not captured at random.

Instead, they disproportionately come in two flavors: the most *emotionally heightened* moment of an experience (the "peak"), and the *final* moment of an experience (the "end"). This is driven by a heuristic that Daniel Kahneman and Barbara Fredrickson refer to as the Peak-End Rule.



Consequently, these two types of moments weigh heavily in how we remember the events, experiences, jobs, and even people in our lives. Understanding this phenomenon gives us a window into how we can shape the shared memories of our culture and the emotions that reverberate within our employees long after any experience has passed.

Crafting your culture, Asai says, is similar to creating a family picture wall at home. "When you do that, you take very deliberate steps to celebrate people, moments, and places you've gone, you

frame those moments and you hang them on the wall." Those moments, he says, become a constant reminder of the family's values—or in the case of an organization, the values and culture of the organization.

When convening everyone in an organization, every moment counts—which is exactly why Asai invested so much in bringing people together in unusual and levity-infused ways. From a gospel choir to a video featuring employees dressed head to toe as the Blue Man Group to an elaborate chase scene (with Asai as the quarry), these moments were carefully crafted to create sensorial peaks—ones that would enliven the experience in the moment and hang on the wall to continue defining the values long after the moment had passed.

This chapter has been chock-full of examples of companies punctuating company gatherings with levity to create peaks—and you know the four archetypes that will disproportionately help you in ensuring that these come alive.

But what about "ends"?

When Gina Amaro Rudan started as "Cultural Alchemist" at Google X, the company's secretive research and development facility that pursued bold, ambitious, seemingly impossible problems, she knew that the team needed a ritual for death—the death of work projects, that is.

Building on well-known ceremonies like Día de los Muertos (the Day of the Dead), Rudan conceived of "Dia X," what soon became an annual companywide celebration in which Google Xers build altars to the prototypes they've killed, deliver eulogies for the businesses they've shut down, and mourn the ideas they've laid to rest. They used levity to punctuate organizationally meaningful "ends."

On the surface, a Day of the Dead might seem like the opposite of lighthearted. But it became a surprisingly joyful way of reinforcing the cultural values of innovativeness and agility that were central to Google X's success. You need to "honor your idea, learn from it," Rudan says. "And we do that every year with a ritual."

But infusing levity into endings doesn't need to be a high-budget companywide affair, as one of our students' experiences illustrates. While at the Boston Consulting Group, he and his team were wrapping up a project for a particularly difficult client. As the project drew to a close, the team was left feeling tense and emotionally drained from the months of thankless work. So the project principal leading the engagement organized a team dinner and emceed an elaborate ceremony during which he gave each team member a "paper plate award" commemorating something funny that had happened during the project, on the back of a—you guessed it—flimsy paper plate.

As our student recalled, "It was a horrible project, but the team nevertheless ended up remembering it (and each other) rather fondly because of the ceremony. Pretty sure I still have that plate."

So remember: People remember peaks and ends. When your employees are asked about your organization's culture, when people approach them inquiring "What is it like to work there?" or "Why should I join?," they will draw upon their spikiest memories.

Make sure they're good ones.

TURN ACCIDENTS INTO FOLKLORE

But designing new, humorous ceremonies and traditions is difficult for some. We get it. And we're here for you.

If these approaches aren't your bag, try instead to lean into your powers of *observation*. Look for *organic* moments of delight, and when you observe those that are resonant with the culture you aspire to have, either get out of the way or support them, and allow them to evolve.

At Ford Smart Mobility's Greenfield labs, where teams are working to discover and build mobility solutions for our tech-enabled transportation future, an engineer once remarked that some problems are "harder than putting socks on a chicken." Tickled by his choice of metaphor, the team instituted a weekly tradition of presenting one member with a pair of wild or weird (or chicken-bedazzled) socks as a way of acknowledging their work. The tradition soon became so integral that new hires and visitors to the lab are, to this day, welcomed into the fold with their own customized and often chicken-themed socks. So many socks are given out that they've become their own budget line item for the lab.

Rituals are the heart of an organization or team's culture. According to researcher Mike Norton at Harvard University, even seemingly odd rituals can become a source of group cohesion. By creating a sense of shared identity and goodwill, rituals inspire commitment, effort, and performance. They often take hold among a small team, then spread organization-wide, becoming so woven into the fabric of the culture that no one can remember a time before they existed.

Much like the most awe-inspiring comics, leaders with this ability are artful observers, keenly able to spot new behaviors or activities that they can formally incorporate into "official" organizational ceremonies—which is exactly what Joey Zwillinger did when an employee approached him with an odd bet.

Zwillinger is the CEO of the trendy sustainable footwear manufacturer, Allbirds. One day in August 2016, a member of the marketing team made a bet with him that they would reach $1.25 million in revenue by the end of that month. It was their sixth month in business and Allbirds was just coming off the retail seasonal lull in July alongside inventory shortages. Zwillinger found the number unreasonably high but played along. When he asked her what was on the line? "A frosé[*9] machine for the office," she teased.

To both of their surprise, Allbirds hit the number. Zwillinger broadcast his loss and not only purchased a frosé machine, but instituted a weekly celebration; Frosé Fridays became a thing,[*10] codifying this one-off joke into an ongoing tradition of levity.

In both these cases, new traditions arose organically, out of happy accidents. As a leader, you can encourage the formation of these spontaneous rituals by looking to your instigators and culture carriers—traditions that flow from the bottom up tend to be more widely and easily adopted, in our

experience, than ones dictated from the top down. Look for *organic* moments of delight, support them, and then get out of the way.

The Walls Can Talk

What does your body language say about you right now?

Are your shoulders back or hunched? Is your mouth leaning more into a smile or a frown? Are you sitting proudly with your head high and chest forward like a royal? (One of the strong ones, not one of those frail Habsburgs.)

Body language speaks volumes. An organization's physical space is no different.

"Physical space is the body language of an organization," says Brendan Boyle, a principal at the global design firm IDEO. "When the verbal and physical language disagree—just like with our body language—the physical language reigns supreme."

There's a reason why tech giants like Google and Facebook hold their meetings in conference rooms with names like "We Didn't Start the Firefox,"[*11] "Steven Tyler's Scarf," and "Toxicated": It sends playful cues to employees, as subtle as a small smile, that levity is welcome.

By now, we've all heard the tales about tech giants' over-the-top work environments, flush with ping-pong tables, trampolines, and colorful slides connecting conference rooms (yes, this is actually a thing).

While turning your office space into a veritable playground can indeed create a breeding ground for levity (and for class action lawsuits), it is by no means the only way. Research has shown that a range of environmental factors—from greater employee autonomy over workspace design to elements as simple as plants and bright colors—can promote engagement, productivity, creativity, and well-being. Work by Justin Berg, an organizational psychologist at Stanford University, shows that the "primal mark''—that is, the first visual cue an employee sees as they generate ideas—anchors the trajectory of novelty and usefulness. When the primal mark is surprising or unusual, creativity often follows.

Indeed, some of the most effective and profound alterations to physical space that we observed were the simplest—small, ever-present winks interwoven throughout physical space that constantly signal "We're here to work, but also to play."

For example, when the leaders of JibJab were first designing the office space at their Los Angeles headquarters, they decided to create and hang a series of enormous signs displaying the company's values, one of which read AGILITY. Or, more accurately, it was *supposed to* read AGILITY. What it actually said was AGLITITY. Oops. But cofounders Gregg and Evan Spiridellis decided to keep the misspelled sign and display it in all its glory as a reminder that the company embraces failure and doesn't take itself too seriously.

Designing a space for levity can go a long way toward reinforcing crucial organizational values. IDEO is a master at this craft, whether it's by encouraging employees to answer funny or thought-provoking prompts posted on the walls, or randomly planting odd surprises throughout the office, like

a mini-golf hole at the base of the toilet. At Forrester, a team created a wall of "quotes of the week" where they would document the funniest moments and phrases, encouraging all employees to be on the lookout for moments of humor and joy throughout the workday. And in 2014, when Tesla announced they would be releasing all of their patents to the public, they commemorated this significant milestone by proudly displaying a play on a popular meme, reading ALL OUR PATENT ARE BELONG TO YOU, on a massive wall in their factory.

At the end of the day, the specific physical modifications matter far less than the precision with which they reflect the unique values and personality of the company culture—the lodestars of what the company is and aspires to be.

Back at Pixar, we're shepherded around the office by Ed Catmull as creatives flutter around their office spaces—which include elaborately decorated desks and even a few little private huts. As longtime Pixar animator and director Brad Bird describes it: "If you walk around downstairs in the animation area, you'll see that it is unhinged. One guy might build a front that's like a Western town. Someone else might do something that looks like Hawaii."

As we pass one office, we notice the outline of an archway drawn on the wall. Noticing our confusion, Ed explains: Pixar has always kept office walls white—a blank canvas so the animators could draw all over them. At one point, an employee took it a bit further, cutting an enormous archway into the wall so he could watch people walk by from the comfort of his own office. Though that employee had since moved on and the next occupant had the hole in the wall filled in, they paid him homage by having an outline of the archway drawn on the wall where the real thing used to be (a work hazard if they ever hire Wile E. Coyote).

This attitude toward office personalization at Pixar is emblematic of Catmull's philosophy of levity in the workplace: "Organic implies a beginning and an end," says Catmull. "We need to let our traditions grow, evolve, and die organically to make room for new ones."

Traditions, in Catmull's view, are things to hold on to lightly; some will fade away, and others will rise to take their place. Just like the archway in that office, leaders must hold respect for the old traditions while letting them fade away so that new ones can emerge. They must trust that they've planted the right seeds and enabled the right people, so that new rituals, traditions, and elements in their physical space will take shape.

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*1 A reference to Mike Judge's paean to white-collar drudgery. If you haven't seen this…yeah, we're gonna need you to go ahead and watch it ASAP. If you could do that, that would be *greeeat*. Which is a reference you'll understand only after you watch it.

*2 Search "Google TGIF 1999 video" on YouTube for a treat. And Google "TGIF $14.99 Menu" to treat yourself to two grill favorites plus mashed potatoes and lemon butter broccoli for an affordable price.

*3 Yes, that was a subtle search engine pun. Please feel free to boo(lean).

*4 That said, if you've got it—flaunt it, sister (sassy snap).

*5 Incidentally, April Fools' Day was a sacred holiday at Sun. They do not mess around. One year, employees transported the entire contents of the CEO's office into a shipping container in the company parking lot.

Another time, an executive's desk was found at the bottom of a tank at the San Francisco Aquarium.

*6 Not to be confused with *Rebel Rousers*, the 1970 American independent outlaw biker film starring Jack Nicholson. Or with rabbit rousers, the people who go around to farms playing bugles by the rabbit warren to let the rabbits know the day has begun.

*7 Naomi was a collegiate athlete and Jennifer works out in flip-flops. We'll let you guess who wrote this sentence.

*8 Now, this is meaningful water cooler conversation.

*9 Portmanteau term for "frozen rosé." In this entire book, this is our fanciest footnote.

*10 That is, a thing most of the team regretted on most Saturdays.

*11 Upon hearing this fact, our friend David Iscoe disappeared for an hour without explanation and emerged with this: a set of historically accurate song lyrics to the tune of "We Didn't Start the Fire." Enjoy:

"We Didn't Start the Firefox" *by David Iscoe*

NCSA, Mosaic, Erwise tanked, it's archaic
Marc Andreesen, James Clark, Barksdale CEO
Netscape Navigator, Godzilla looked like a gator
Number one market share, killer IPO
Netscape sold to AOL, product support went to hell
iPlanet, disbanded, nowhere left to go
AOL went bad to worse, Mozilla went open source
Foundation, Corporation, deprecated suite
Firefox, Thunderbird, friendly hackers spread the word
Bugzilla, Gecko, Pocket if you read
We didn't start the Firefox
It's as old as trousers
Since the world's had browsers
We didn't start the Firefox
No, we didn't code it
But our iPhones load it

Chapter 6: Creating a Culture of Levity

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